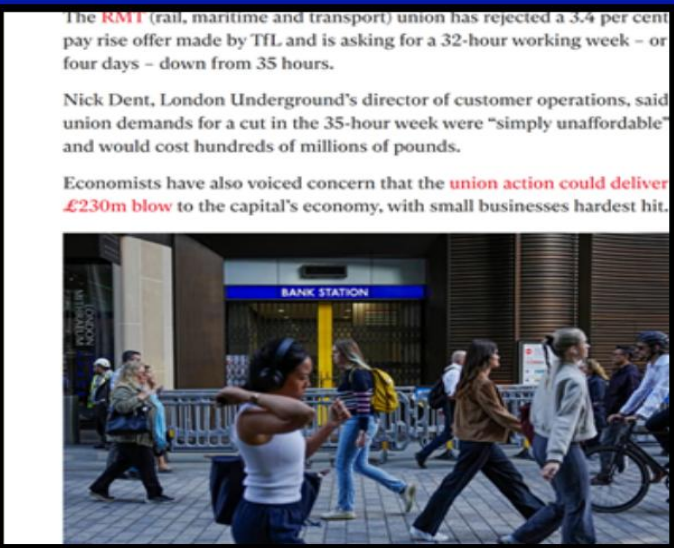
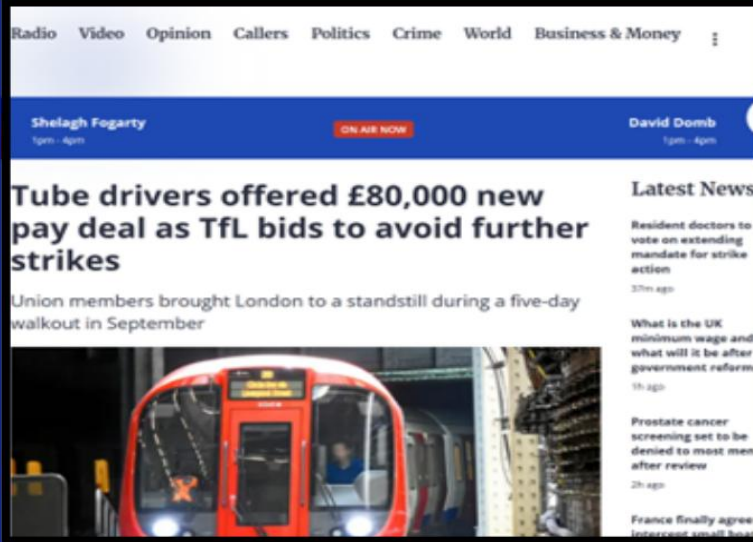




Are Train Drivers Greedy?

BY DANIEL JONES
(W2086277)

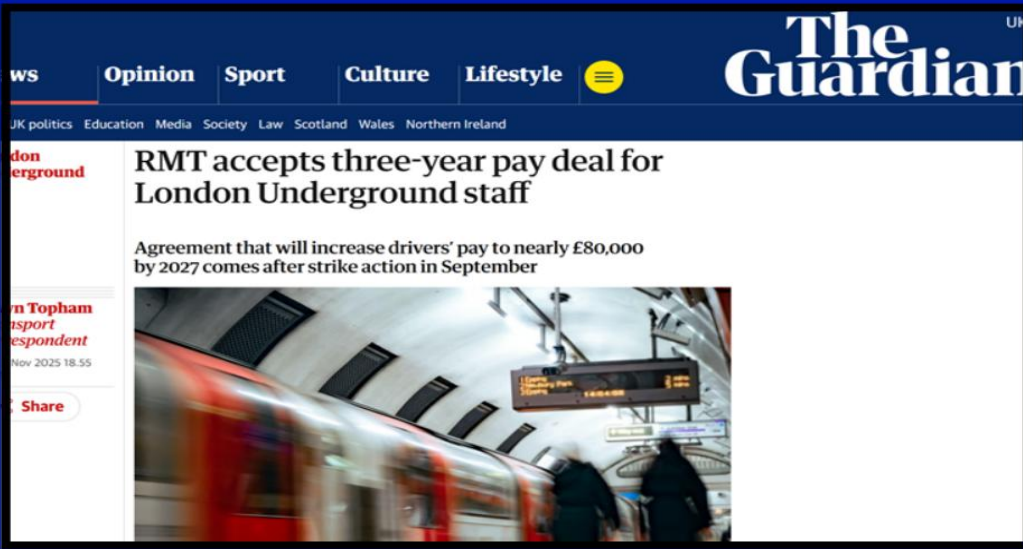


Figure 1. Collage of screenshots from news reports covering London Underground driver pay and strike negotiations and images.
Sources: Dom J (2017); Euronews (2025); Evening Standard (2018); Evening Standard (2025); LBC (2025); Marianna (2016); The Guardian (2025); The Independent (2025).

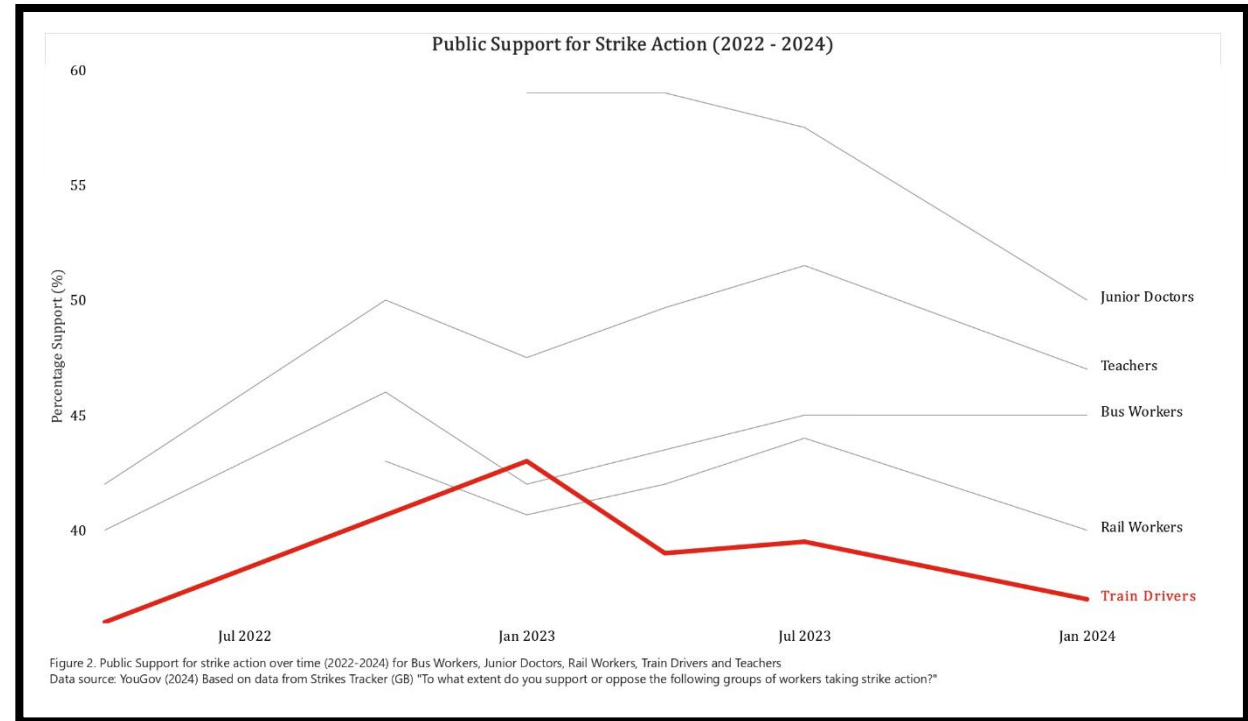
Are Train Drivers greedy?

It seems there are always strikes, whether it's junior doctors in healthcare, teachers in education or the often-criticised train drivers in the transport industry.

Even though each group strikes for similar reasons, the public support and sentiment varies considerably. You hear about the pay train drivers receive for “sitting down all day” and “pushing a couple of buttons” and begin to think, “a bit greedy eh”.

A poll conducted by YouGov on support for strikes between 2022 and 2024 illustrates the differences in public sentiment. Visualising these groups we usually hear about, shows the variation in support.

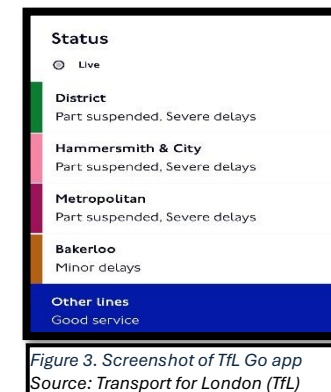
Figure 2 shows the fluctuating support for strikes across groups and as expected, we see that train drivers consistently receive lower average support compared to other groups.



Well, that makes sense right? They are asking for more money, but train times are unreliable at best.

I even decided to quickly check the TfL Go app and look at what I saw (figure 3).

Part A



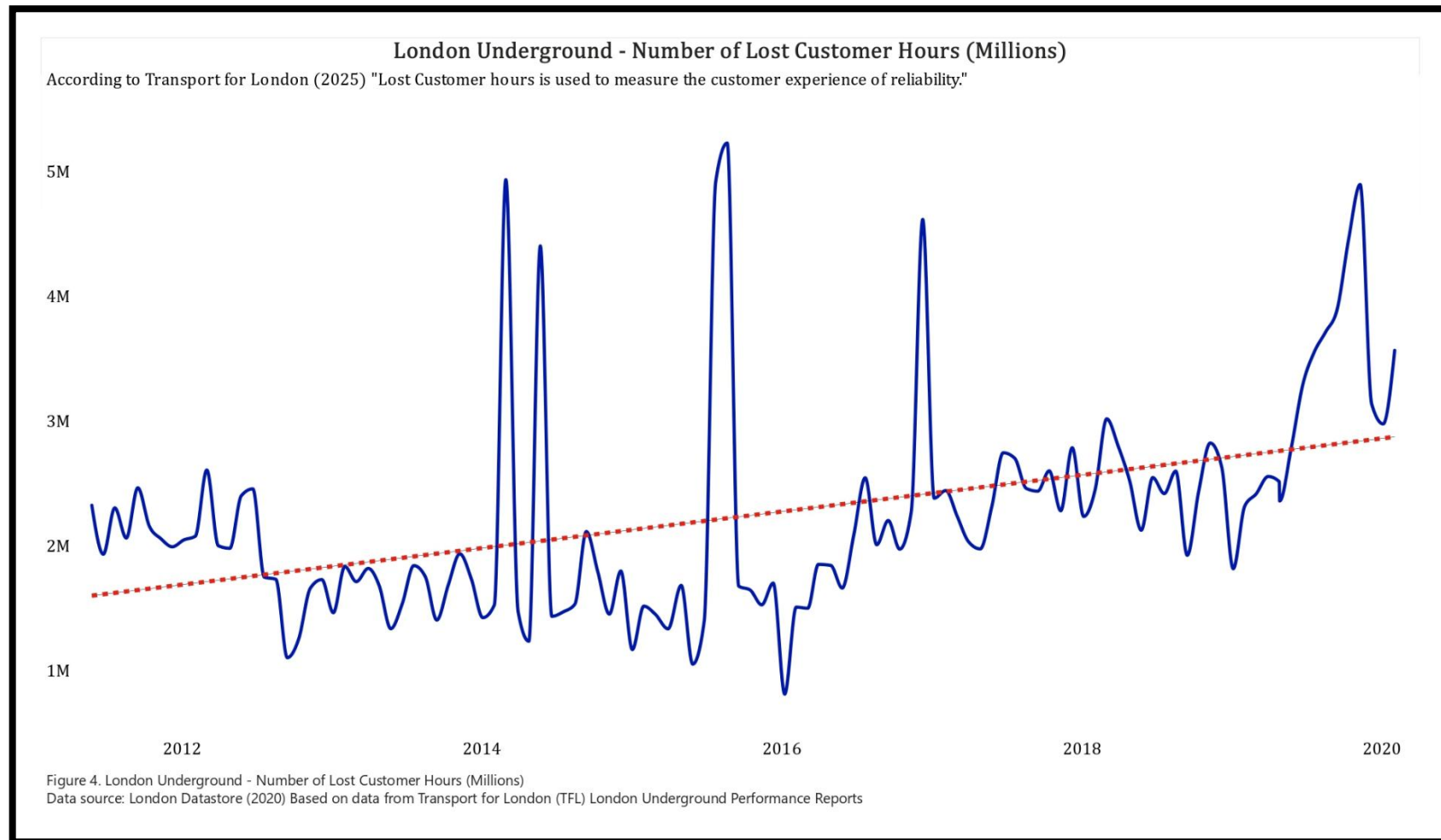
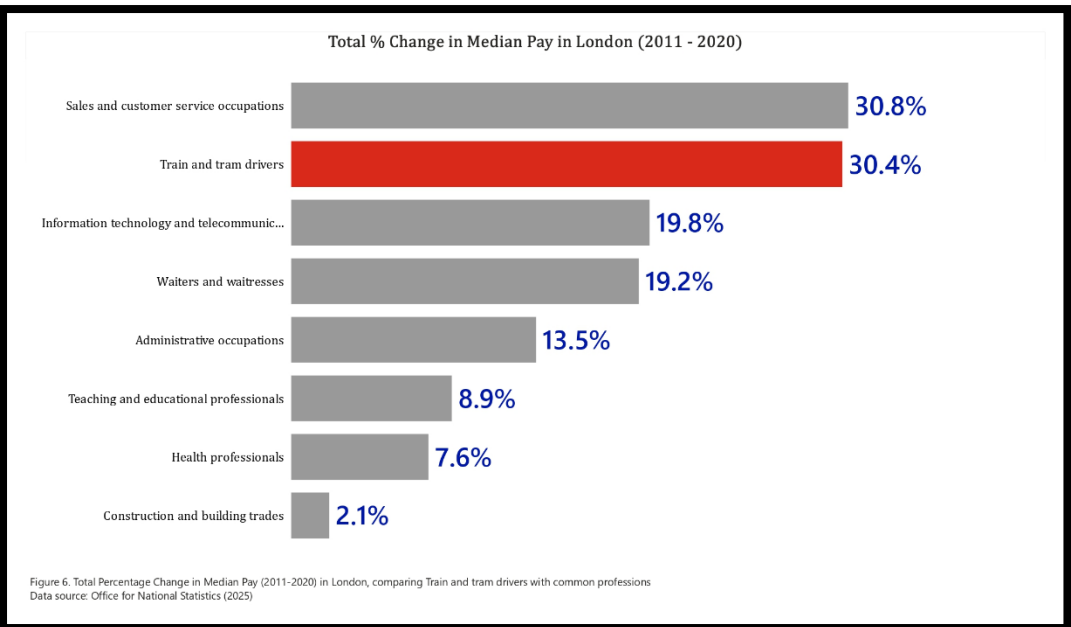
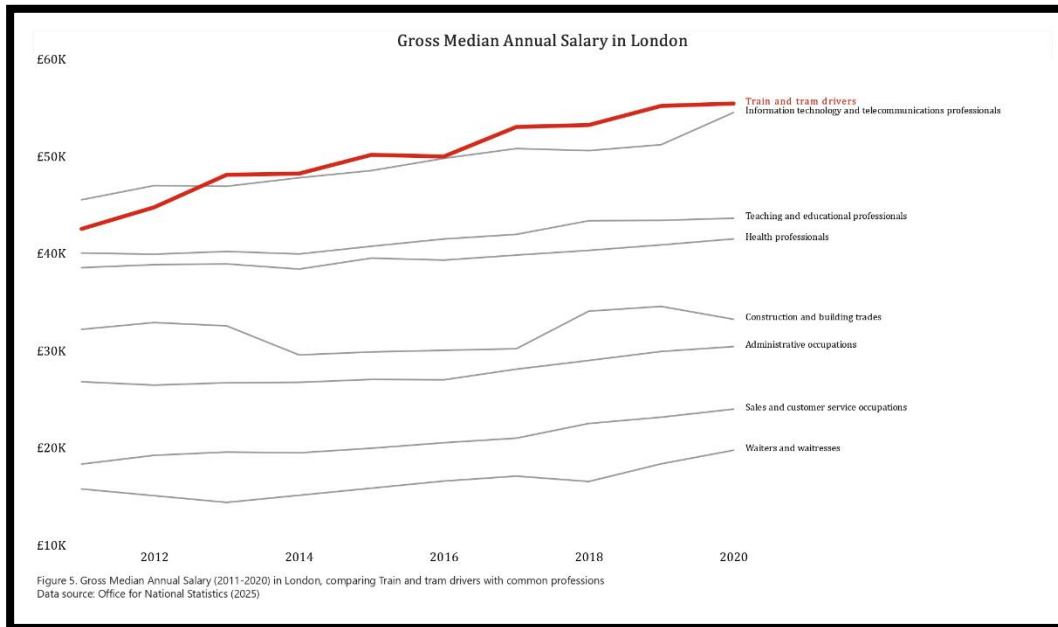


Figure 4 shows the lost customer hours on the London Underground over time, which is a key performance metric used by Transport for London (TfL) to assess service reliability. The data clearly indicates a deterioration in performance over time so, how could train drivers, especially for London Underground, possibly justify a pay increase?

The question becomes even controversial when salaries are compared to other common professions.



Figures 5 and 6 show that train and tram drivers have experienced relatively consistent growth in median pay, whereas other professions had periods of stagnation. In total, their median pay increased by 30.4% between 2011 and 2020 compared to Teaching professionals with just 8.9% and Health professionals with only 7.6%.

So that's it right? We have our answer. I mean, the data proves it?

This interpretation relies on a narrow, London-centric view and ignores wider trends in pay. Shifting focus to an international context, paints a different picture.

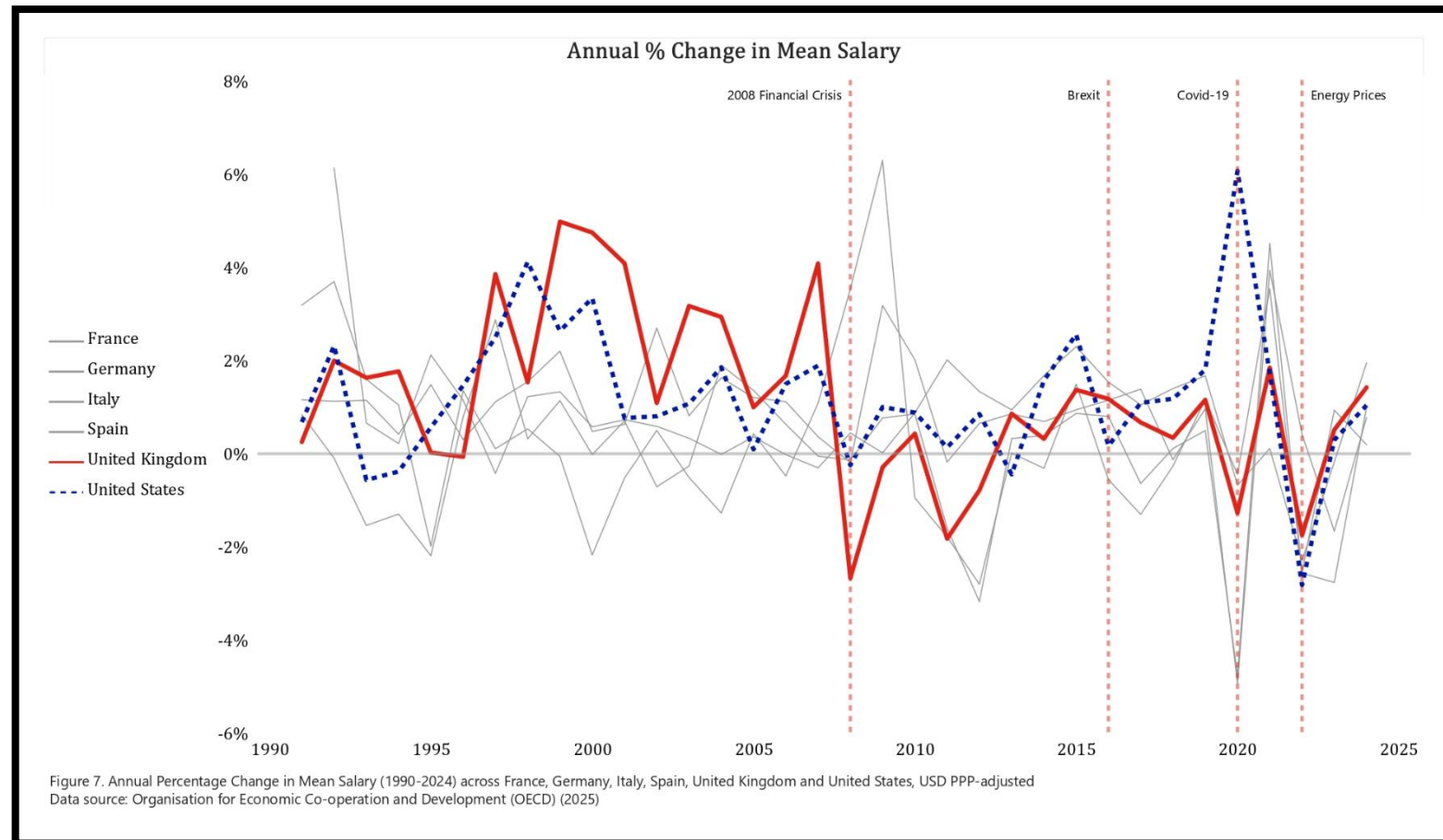


Figure 7 shows the annual percentage change in mean salary for the UK compared to the US and several Western European countries. Since 2008, UK wage growth has been weaker than the United States. Brexit related uncertainty, the pandemic, and the cost-of-living crisis/increase in energy prices have all further constrained real growth in the UK.

If pay growth in the UK has been so weak for over the past decade, the question shifts from questioning their greediness to “How are they among the few workers able to protect their pay?”

How do they protect their pay?

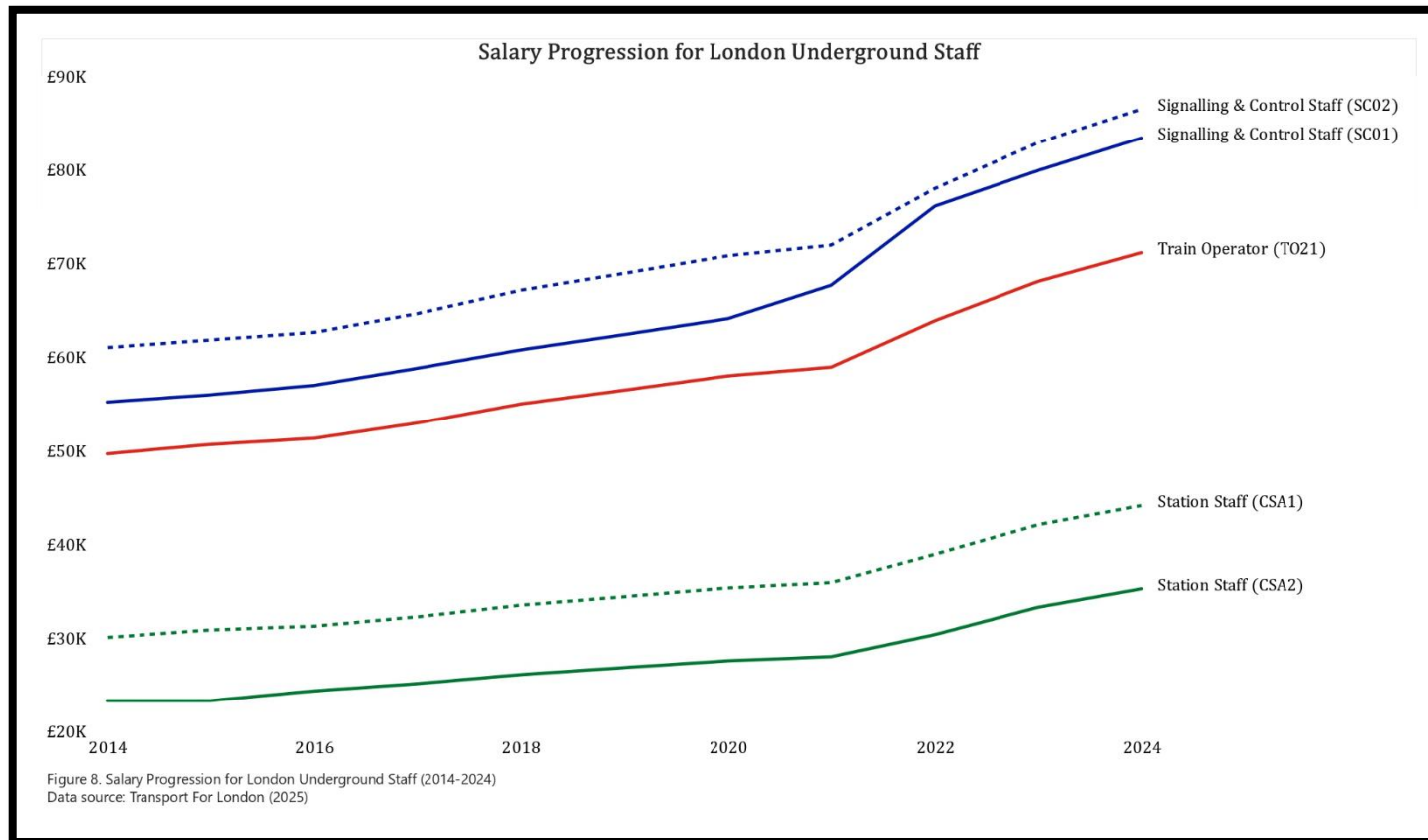


Figure 8 shows that since 2014, not only Train Operators but also Station and Signalling & Control staff experienced near identical growth in pay. This could suggest that pay is not driven by moral character (greediness) but by the collective strength of the workforce. But why?

The reality is that London Underground staff are among the most organised workers in the UK.

The importance of Unions

The main representing unions are RMT and ASLEF which frequently coordinate industrial action. The resulting disruptions are significant as roles are difficult to replace and are central to the function of the economy.

According to The Centre for Economics and Business Research (CEBR), the tube strike which lasted from September 7th 2025 to September 11 2025 “could impose a direct economic cost of around £230 million” and was only backed by just above half of RMT members.

This demonstrates how strike action on the Underground carries a greater weight and leverage than in other areas of public transport.

By contrast, London Overground staff have fragmented employers while bus drivers are not even employed directly by TfL resulting in disputes being rarely coordinated, meaning passengers can often take alternative routes which reduces the pressure on employers to concede to demands.

September 4, 2025

The Standard: Tube strike set to deliver £230m blow to London economy was backed by just 57% of RMT members

A massive Tube strike that could deliver a £230m blow to London's economy was backed by just over half of union members, it can be revealed. RMT members are preparing to walk out from Sunday – and Transport for London has warned commuters to expect “little to no service” on the Underground between Monday and Thursday next week and, overall, six consecutive days of chaos.

The strike, which threatens transport misery for three million daily Tube passengers, was called by the RMT executive after just over 6,000 members gave their backing – despite almost 4,200 deciding to “sit on their hands” and not take part in the ballot.

Union members voted to take action – before hearing from TfL about the 3.4 per cent pay rise that has been proposed.

TfL has called on RMT chiefs to give Tube staff an opportunity to vote on whether they accept the pay rise.

Research by the central London-based Centre for Economics and Business Research, carried out for The Standard, estimates the strikes will cause a direct £230m hit to the capital's economy – and countless millions more in indirect impacts.

Business leaders have warned the strike will have a dire impact on the capital's struggling economy. TfL bosses have pleaded with the RMT to back down.

While many commuters will be able to work from home, and the Elizabeth line and London Overground will continue to operate, central London retailers, bars and restaurants all face a noticeable fall in customers.

The CEBR said: “Our analysis suggests that next week's Tube and DLR strikes could impose a direct economic cost of around £230 million, reflecting the loss of roughly 700,000 working days across both TfL staff and the wider commuter base.

“These figures only capture the immediate disruption, but the true economic hit is likely to be significantly higher once the indirect effects are considered.

“Experience from previous strikes shows that London businesses face reduced productivity as staff struggle to get into the office or arrive late, while shops, restaurants and leisure venues typically suffer from weaker footfall and lower consumer spending.

“On top of that, congestion on London's roads is expected to increase sharply as people switch from the Underground to cars, taxis and buses, further adding to delays and lost output.

Figure 9. Article by The Standard on September tube strikes
Sources: Centre for Economics and Business Research (CEBR); The Standard

My personal thoughts

Viewed from this angle, pay outcomes reflect bargaining power instead of moral character or greed. They are just positioned uniquely within a system where collective action is highly effective. In fact, I personally would argue TfL's moral character could be called into question as they silently sneak into your bank account at 3am putting your account £15.10 into overdraft.

It's hard to ignore the possibility that the breaking up of London's transport network was intended to limit the effects of industrial action and thus limit the need to give into demands. While that's just my theory, I believe this organisational structure will continue and the relatively new Elizabeth Line seems to support this.

Your main take away should be to fight for what you believe you deserve and don't get mad at other hard-working individuals because you refuse to try to change anything about your current situation. If you can't beat them. Join them.

Methodology

My research question didn't take much refining as I began with the idea of a deliberately provocative research question and due to the London Underground strikes prior to the start of the semester, I already had a research idea. The aim was to engage readers while critically examining feelings news articles can invoke, of train drivers being greedy and whether it's supported by data. Rather than continuously refining the question, I focused on selecting data that could challenge or support this assumption.

My initial exploratory work involved looking for media coverage of strikes to understand how train drivers are portrayed as that's how many will subconsciously form their opinion, especially if you take public transport to work and end up late. Playing to those emotions before flipping it on its head helped guide my selection of relevant datasets from official statistical sources and public open data portals. Data was not chosen to confirm a conclusion but to progressively lead analysis towards one, reducing risk of wasted time on excessive data manipulation without relevance to the narrative.

When suitable data was unavailable, I submitted a freedom of information request to TfL (FOI-3353-2526). Due to time constraints for both of us, the request was strategically narrowed down to provide the most analytical value.

Data prep and transformation was carried out using a combination of Excel, Python and Power BI, however Power BI was used for all exploratory analysis and visualisations.

Use of Generative AI

I made a deliberate decision to limit my use of generative AI for this assessment. It can be useful, but I am cautious of becoming too dependent as I believe it can restrict original thinking by forcing you into a box. For a data storytelling task, I felt like it was important for it to be my own work I could be proud of.

Gen AI was primarily used at the exploratory stage. ChatGPT was used to suggest relevant news articles for background research and to identify potential data providers that may have suitable datasets, which helped accelerate the research phase without affecting the direction of my story.

I previously experimented with using ChatGPT for Power BI outside of the assessment, but it never worked as intended which is why I mostly avoided it after gathering my data. Personally, the only use would have been for describing what you are struggling with and have it guide to the section, but every time ChatGPT would inform me it's not possible in Power BI or too convoluted.

Overall, I believe generative AI is a good tool for building foundational knowledge if paired with external sources and good for pointing you in the right direction at each step instead of a complete substitute for analytical thinking or technical skill.

What went well and What could be improved?

The first strength of this project would be the choice and quality of data sources. When possible, data was obtained directly from official and authoritative sources, including Transport for London itself, through a Freedom of Information request. This increased the credibility of analysis.

The research question was intentionally provocative and well suited for a target audience of underpaid and overworked workers as well as those who use public transport frequently who may encounter discussions of strikes in everyday media. This framing helped capture attention and build an easy interpretation of the data before deliberately flipping the entire story on its head and using the data as visual evidence to argue that pay outcomes reflect union strength rather than individual greed.

From a visual perspective, I paid strong attention to clarity and accessibility. I focused on a high data ink ratio by removing unnecessary gridlines, legends and labels that didn't add value. I tried to keep colours consistent and minimal with less important comparison lines greyed out to guide the readers focus. I also really tried to focus on accessibility by ensuring graphs were readable in black and white, using line thickness, dashed lines, series labels and font size to support readers with colour vision deficiencies.

On the other hand, there are still many areas for improvement. The narrative relies on a leading question which despite being effective for engagement, may reduce the perception of academic neutrality. Also, the use of multiple line charts in succession risks visual fatigue and more images could have been used to break up text. I had plans to use alternative graphs such as scatter plots comparing wages and railway usage across cities in Europe, but it was too big of a challenge and time sink when attempting to integrate multiple datasets and define metrics for comparison. I also didn't want to add images that provided no value.

The analysis also has some inconsistencies such as switching between, mean, median and spot-rate values that are used across different datasets which makes direct comparison more difficult. Also, the focus shifts between national and London specific data and also between different occupation definitions which reflects the limits of available data. Time periods also varies between visualisations. Lastly, the comparison of occupations relies on SOC codes at different aggregation levels which may affect interpretability. Despite these limitations, the data story successfully communicates a clear and engaging argument supported by data and analysis.

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